PROTAGONIST GUIDE TO CAREERS

Achieve your career goals while finding new ways to serve and uplift others

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Academic and Professional Development Matter for Protagonists

Protagonists tend to feel a sense of mission in their lives – specifically, a mission to make a positive difference in the world around them. With their creativity and their proactive energy, Protagonists find all sorts of ways to uplift others and make things better on nearly a daily basis.

As people with this personality type go about their life's mission, they often feel called to develop specialized skills that can enhance their ability to help others. This is why academic and professional development are so important for Protagonists. Throughout their schooling and their careers, Protagonists can search for – and make the most of – opportunities to expand their knowledge and their abilities in ways that will help them to make a positive impact.

Not every academic environment or every workplace will be perfectly aligned with Protagonists' altruistic goals. In these pages, we'll discuss how – even in imperfect situations – Protagonists can find outlets for inspiration and creativity, how they can make the most of their gifts in a variety of careers, and how they can build healthy, productive relationships even with coworkers who don't see eye to eye with them. Along the way, you'll learn how Protagonists can create academic and professional lives that not only uphold their values but also inspire them to grow into their best selves.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Academic Path

Better Self, Better World

Unlike some idealists who simply dream of a better and more just world, Protagonists work tirelessly to spread their message. War, poverty, racism: These are some the most fundamental problems we face as a species. Many see these ills as unfortunate but ultimately the way of the world, therefore trying to change them would be futile. Protagonists, however, balk at this apathy and instead dedicate their lives to eradicating one or more of society's ills through action and community involvement.

Once Protagonists have a goal in mind, their motivation is nearly unparalleled among the types. Their urge to learn and improve themselves doesn't come from a desire to simply be better, but rather to be better for those around them. As summed up in a quotation from author Joseph Campbell: "We're not on our journey to save the world, but to save ourselves. But in doing that, you save the world. The influence of a vital person vitalizes."

Protagonists take the moral obligation to better themselves for the sake of others and apply it to their studies. They don't learn just to learn, they learn with a purpose. Every book read, every essay written, and every debate they engage contribute to a well-rounded education that will aid them – and others – in the future.

Honing a Vision

Protagonists are beyond diligent when it comes to their studies. People of this type are famous throughout history for their extraordinary

impact on the world: Consider the likes of Barack Obama and Oprah Winfrey. Protagonists' campaigns often begin with learning, then are seen through with dedication and hard-honed vision. They have the rare ability to focus on both breadth and depth. Their missions have the capacity to change things, but they are general enough to be broadly applied. Whatever their mission, they will discover it through studies of both subjects and people, then apply all their focus. This can be anything from ending poverty to creating a comic that gives representation to the underrepresented. For Protagonists, the possibilities are endless.

From the time they're young, Protagonists have acute emotional ties to those around them. Their motivation comes from wanting to create a better world for people, and they create plans in which they are the catalysts that launch revolution. For young Protagonists, when their teacher asks what they want to be when they grow up, they often have a clear idea in mind, as well as sustained intent that follows them well into their adult lives.

This may manifest itself as joining the newspaper staff in high school, then majoring in journalism at college, with the eventual goal of winning a Peabody Award for investigative journalism examining the government of a far-off, neglected, impoverished country. They begin with emotion, then develop a vision, and then begin to map the steps from point A to point B.

How Protagonists Learn

There is no right way to learn, and every single type has their own unique style of processing information. Protagonists' style of learning is heavily influenced by those around them, and often, it is a powerful tool that fuels the machine. By developing and balancing their natural style, Protagonists can optimize and enjoy the process of learning.

Balanced Learning Habits

Considering Impact

In addition to being attentive listeners and careful thinkers, Protagonists possess an insatiable curiosity, directed particularly at humanistic

enterprises, whether directly or indirectly, such as engineering. For Protagonists, such activities represent the very essence of humanity at its best. They are likely to agree with the following quote from the film "Dead Poets Society":

> *"We don't read and write poetry because it's cute. We read and write poetry because we are members of the human race. And the human race is filled with passion. And medicine, law, business, engineering – these are noble pursuits and necessary to sustain life. But poetry, beauty, romance, love – these are what we stay alive for."*

Protagonists are more than just motivated by creative and artistic endeavors – it is often one of the reasons they love life. Although they certainly make themselves knowledgeable in many fields, from the physical sciences to math, economics, business, and beyond, they always feel most at home being of service to the heart and soul of human expression, using those many subjects to that end.

That's why when it comes to school, Protagonists are often concerned with what their work portrays. It's about more than needing to please the public; they strive to fulfill a need in the people whom they're trying to help. Although they value their original goals, Protagonists may pivot if they see a certain direction being more beneficial to their intended audience. It's less about *"How do I feel about this?"* and more about *"How can this best help others?"*

Trying the Mundane

Although Protagonists prefer and specialize in subjects that have great meaning to them, they also understand the need to learn "mundane" skills. In day-to-day life, examples include filing taxes, filling out a check, and changing a tire. In an academic context, this could mean taking time to develop long-term study habits for classes they don't enjoy. They do so because they understand that such skills, though not dreamy and inspiring, are necessary to managing everyday life and advancing their inspirations.

Rather than shrugging off the things they aren't inherently interested in, Protagonists dig in their heels and commit to at least attempting to master the material in front of them. They are propelled forward

by the sense that the march through the swamp of mundanity is only temporary, and that the skills they're learning will soon support the work they consider meaningful.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Tied to Others

Protagonists are so intertwined with the emotions and needs of others that they run the risk of being held back by them. For example, while learning, they may slow their own learning pace to match that of their self-designated pack. Protagonists push hard to raise others during their own rise. If others can't rise, they gladly take the time needed until even the last member can cross the finish line. No matter how noble that may seem, Protagonists ultimately starve their own academic ambitions to satiate another's.

In group work, Protagonists often get hung up trying to help everyone succeed. They are susceptible to getting caught up in their emotions: They want to "give voice" to others, but they ultimately risk undermining their own confidence – and grades.

Obsessing about Impact

Solving the unsolvable can take a toll on even the hardiest individuals, and Protagonists can exaggerate this tendency. They shoulder the burdens of the world and are at risk of being crushed beneath the weight. Feeling that they personally can't be at peace until they help everyone, Protagonists can become obsessive in their learning behaviors, leaving little time in their schedules for relaxation and self-care. In extreme cases, Protagonists may even skip meals or lose sleep as they study through their lunch breaks or read late into the night.

These workaholic tendencies, though intense, have limits to their scope. When left alone too long with their thoughts, Protagonists may develop "tunnel vision," relentlessly pursuing areas of study that seem most relevant. They may even temporarily eliminate all forms of enjoyment and relaxation to reach their goals more quickly. However, this can put their bodies and mental well-being under immense stress, as well as diminish the quality of their work.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Making Themselves Equal

Protagonists go out of their way to meet the needs of those around them and ignore their own desires in the process (in extreme cases, they may be completely unaware of their own needs and desires), which leads to an unbalanced approach to learning. To rebalance this, they should develop a valuable skill: giving their personal priorities the same importance they give to others' needs.

Doing so may feel selfish for these dutiful types, but learning this skill leads to a more fulfilling life. Protagonists can start by first acknowledging their desires, even while considering another person's perspective. Some steps to get there:

- Listen to the other person's perspective.
- Write down the pros and cons of that perspective.
- Write down the pros and cons of your own approach.
- Take points from both to create the most evolved approach.

Protagonists can listen to others while also giving their own ideas equal weight, allowing both parties to have an enjoyable and enlightening learning experience.

Combining Rest and Impact

Food, sleep, and even leisure time are all necessities, not luxuries – a fact that Protagonists are much quicker to remind others of than to accept themselves. When people with this personality type make personal sacrifice a routine, they soon find that they have nothing left to give. It's important for Protagonists to make these necessities a priority, not an afterthought.

Protagonists may need to purposefully schedule time for meals, rest, and relaxation. Using an alarm can be a good reminder to take a break. And quality can be as crucial as quantity. A series of two- to three-hour naps interspersed throughout the day don't equal eight hours of uninterrupted rest, though a 20-minute nap in addition to nightly rest makes a tremendous difference. Also, a fast-food burrito gobbled down during a commute may provide needed calories, but it can't

compare to a balanced breakfast. Protagonists can use the following considerations to determine their needs and then meet them:

- Consider how you're currently spending your time. Are your primary needs being met? Before answering, consider what you would expect to be enough for any of your loved ones. Would you chastise a friend for taking a small nap after a heavy study session or encourage self-care?
- If your primary needs are not being met, ask yourself: How can you meet your needs in short increments? 10 minutes for a nap? An hour to cook a good meal? 30 minutes of cuddling with your significant other?
- Schedule in your calendar some time every day, at the same time, to fulfill one need. Such moments, no matter how small, are important to rebooting the brain and body. A 20-minute nap helps people focus, a healthy meal fuels the body, and time with a loved one provides inspiration.

Protagonists in High School

In high school, Protagonists are likely to establish their vision then make an effort to do what needs to be done to achieve it (e.g., extracurricular activities, concurrent jobs, volunteering, community-oriented decisions). This may include taking action to support any goals they may have for higher education.

This behavior can be a balanced approach, where they strive to get what they can from the opportunities of high school. But they can become unbalanced if they burn themselves out by taking on too much or if they get discouraged by the scope of their vision.

Selectively Brilliant

When discussing an individual Protagonist high school student, teachers of differing subjects may feel like they're talking about completely different people. Some teachers may see the Protagonist student as bright, focused, and driven, but others may wonder why they don't consistently see those traits when the student is in *their* class. For example, one project may be inspired while another is clearly a generic "get the grade and move on" piece of work.

When Protagonists connect with a subject, they may appear to be brilliant and forward-thinking in the essays they write, whether in response to the deeply moral themes of Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment* or the stirring history of the American Civil Rights movement. Although their classmates may see such work as a tedious but necessary hurdle to overcome on the path to graduation, Protagonists may experience the kindling of a passion that holds through their adult lives.

Learning for Authenticity

The humanities and social sciences strike a natural chord within young Protagonists' hearts, but they often experience dissonance when they are exposed to less soulful studies. No topic is beyond Protagonists' grasp, but without some means of putting rote facts, figures, and seemingly arbitrary calculations into a broader human context, Protagonists may perform poorly, or only just well enough to move forward. Their lack of interest in such classes may frustrate teachers and parents alike, both of whom may struggle to comprehend how academic passions could be distributed so unevenly.

Protagonists' curious behavior is a consequence of their steady inner compass, lending them a warm and fierce integrity that makes them mature beyond their years. At a time when their peers' identities are malleable as clay, Protagonists are stubborn marble. Others' approval matters to Protagonists, but remaining in sync with their ideals always matters more. They hold themselves to a very high moral standard, and they don't need to fit in if it means going against their ideals.

Balanced High School Learning

Remaining Open to Possibilities

A fortunate few Protagonists may encounter teachers who supply inspirational context for every stray fact or theorem, who discuss topics more deeply than the facts that will be on the test, who explore why the information taught matters. Most of the time, however, Protagonists need to sharpen their contextualization skills on their own to excel in subjects that don't come easily to them. Protagonists with a balanced point of view put into context even those subjects they don't naturally embrace. They can see each topic as a necessary component of their

broader goal and recognize that every vision comes with sometimes unpleasant tasks along the way. For example, sketching the chemical structure of a hydrocarbon may seem like busywork – until Protagonists begin to ruminate on the possibilities of chemistry to solve world hunger or cure devastating diseases. The motivating potential of Protagonists' passion cannot be understated.

Protagonists who take a balanced approach to high school learning open themselves up to alternatives. They may look to the Socratic paradox for inspiration: "I know one thing: that I know nothing." Such Protagonists recognize that hard and sometimes unforgiving work is needed to make their visions a reality, and that they *always* need to expand their knowledge base. They gather their well-rounded insights and take meaningful steps toward realizing a better world.

Realistic Standards

Protagonists subscribe to a work ethic that correlates directly with their passion, and they tend to keep working without breaks when their passions are ignited. They dislike the idea of leaving their commitments and moral obligations unfulfilled. That said, Protagonists who approach their studies with a balanced mindset aren't keen on sacrificing their health to meet a goal, nor are they overly perfectionistic. They do what they can to turn in quality work but avoid agonizing over the details when there's little to gain. They schedule time to commit the effort needed to succeed, but they set realistic expectations.

Protagonists also aren't completely against letting loose every occasionally. They take their interests very seriously, yes, but they aren't completely against hanging out with friends on a school night – taking time to remember that they're just teenagers. They don't expect to have everything figured out; much of their joy is in the discovery.

Unbalanced High School Learning

Dismissing Details

Protagonists who spend math class doing work for a more interesting course or more pressing project aren't demonstrating traditional teenage rebellion, but their grades can plummet as surely as if they spent

their time shooting spitballs or sending secret texts. In a larger sense, Protagonists who pursue their narrow scholarly obsessions with no concern for the broader curriculum may discover that their knowledge gaps limit them in unforeseeable ways. Budding environmentalists with a tenuous grasp of the underpinnings of climate science will find that their convictions only convince the already-converted.

Protagonists who indulge only in their interests may establish the troublesome habit of ignoring finer details, hindering their progress even in classes that interest them. Young Protagonists with a passion for history intuitively understand the importance of individual events without feeling the need to memorize actual dates for a test, but that can affect their grades. Students with a more literary bent might have points deducted from even the most articulate essay due to a failure to properly cite their sources. Protagonists' refusal to meet the demands of a rigid curriculum can hold them back, both short and long term. A few such bad experiences may cause them to drift away from an academic path that previously felt like destiny, in which they could have done lots of good.

Impossible Standards

Other hurdles for Protagonists to overcome in high school are their relentless and uncompromising vision and ambition, which all too often manifest as work that is turned in late or not at all. Unbalanced Protagonists tend to bite off more than they can chew, sometimes refusing to be compassionate to themselves by taking paths that aren't as stressful. Protagonists may discover they can't possibly get done what they set out to achieve in the time allotted, leading to stress and rushed work. They may even believe that it isn't worth it to "settle," deciding not to complete a project at all if it isn't the absolute best work possible.

High school students are faced with frequent, non-negotiable deadlines. Unbalanced Protagonists, with their Judging trait, are likely to work for 48 hours straight to try to hit the target, often leading to burnout and incomplete work. Then, even with their effort, they'll be exceptionally hard on themselves for their perceived failure, judging themselves for not being a good enough student to do things properly.

Rebalancing High School Learning

Forming a Connection

Learning about details, no matter how mundane, is an important part of life. Ask any student who has graduated high school – only to wonder how to apply for financial aid for college, how to interview properly for a job, or how to keep track of future deadlines. Protagonists try not to neglect their work, but they may feel reluctant to lend the same passion to everyday details as they do to their visions. To rebalance, they must choose to have faith that routine, technical, day-to-day information will prove its value.

When Protagonists have trouble in a course, here are some suggestions:

- Remind yourself that just showing up counts for something.
- Approach the instructor and ask for guidance.
- Develop a mentorship relationship with the instructor (or teacher's assistant or fellow student who is excelling in the course).
- Focus on the that person's point of view, filtering the course through their perspective – it's no longer just geology, it's "Ms. Smith's passion for the Earth expressed through teaching, a childhood dream that found a way into the real world."
- Take any information gained and apply it to the course with new insight.

When coursework becomes more personal, Protagonists can look at some of the details – cited sources, dates memorized – as a favor to the teacher, something they are geared toward naturally. It's not the teacher's fault they have to hand out tests, so it's not fair to the teacher (or to Protagonists themselves) to punish them with poor performance.

Protagonists are perfectly capable of dealing with mundane tasks if they find a way to make them personally relevant. By creating a relationship with someone else involved in a task, the topic and its specifics become more relevant, boosting Protagonists' motivation and attention.

Tempering Unrealistic Expectations

High school can be difficult. With the added pressures of the future,

parents, peers, and extracurricular activities, it can be exhausting, perhaps downright back-breaking to expectation-laden Protagonists. When they commit, they always try to do their best; if something has to give, they often sacrifice themselves to sustain their other obligations.

Protagonists who learn to take a kinder, more measured view of themselves may find that their accomplishments and efforts, even if short of an idealized vision, are still worth taking pride in. Sacrificing themselves under the weight of idealized expectations is not the way to go. In an academic context, young Protagonists can develop healthy school-life balance by creating a schedule. This will not only boost their productivity, but also allow them time to hang out with friends, be alone and relax, and enjoy their lives as teenagers, rather than burning out trying to meet unrealistic expectations. Some suggestions:

- **Create a fixed schedule.** Work when you need to work, and rest when you need to rest. Dedicate time to study, then *stop* when that time is over. Setting a schedule allows Protagonists to have an "off" button they usually deny themselves, making it a personal act of kindness, as well as a sanity saver. An example: one hour of dedicated studying time during school hours (study hall, perhaps) and two hours after school.
- **When it is time to study**, focus on the most important or time-sensitive tasks first – an essay due tomorrow, followed by 50 math equations due by the end of the week, followed by 30 minutes of reading to finish an assigned novel by the end of the month.
- **Limit distractions to only what's relevant.** Turn off your phone, log out of social media, and remove yourself from social situations that could keep you from doing your work.
- **Relax after time is up.** When the designated study time is over, stop and do something relaxing and rewarding, maybe finally sit down to finish the TV show you've been missing for two months.

By tempering unrealistic expectations, Protagonists will find themselves in a more balanced state of mind. With this mindset, they're better able to achieve their goals and enjoy their time as a teenager.

Deciding Whether and When to Attend College

Though Protagonists are by many measures an uncommon personality type, they face a common dilemma when leaving high school: Should they immediately go into the world of work, or should they continue their studies?

Choosing College

For some Protagonists, the choice is moot: Academic certification is required in many fields they might be drawn to, including education, psychotherapy, health care, and law. Without a college education, they will find that those doors remain locked. Such Protagonists have a non-negotiable stopover on their journey to becoming whom they wish to be.

For those who choose college, the experience doesn't have to be a chore. Many Protagonists find their crusade to improve humanity to be an integral part of the curriculum, as well as an important part of their extracurricular activities. Through the simple camaraderie of so many like-minded people – finally! – their flower of rebellion has space to bloom.

Choosing Work

Some Protagonists choose work over college, whether they cannot bear the costs of college (personal, financial, practical, or principled) or their zeal for change is so potent that it just can't be deferred any longer. No longer guided by the educational system and having less and less parental oversight, such Protagonists need time to define themselves and their goals. It's reasonable to work in entry-level positions, such as waiting tables or doing physical work, while continuing a path of self-discovery. Working to explore interests and perhaps save money for future schooling is a balanced reason to delay school in favor of work.

Others know full well what they want and find rewarding careers or work for themselves. They might also take paths somewhere in between, for instance, using recognition for their community service to secure a role in a not-for-profit organization, or using their passion for writing to sell freelance articles while still dealing with the reality of paying the bills.

It's important for Protagonists to realize that many roads can be rewarding. If they truly wish to build a better world, they'll find a way to do so, even if their role is different than they or others had originally anticipated.

Balanced Decision-Making

Embracing Honesty

The important thing is for Protagonists to consider their options with unwavering honesty. The difficulty of this task shouldn't be underestimated. Protagonists know perhaps better than anyone how good people are at deceiving themselves, but even though they see it in others, they are not immune to it themselves. Protagonists who recognize this very human tendency within ask themselves questions, consult with friends and mentors, and do other reality checks that help them gather a range of opinions and information to help orient and clarify their worldviews.

Any option can be either just the challenge Protagonists need to move their visions forward or a means of escape from the weight of responsibility. It can be all too easy to convince themselves that one is the other. Protagonists, when honest and patient with themselves, distinguish between an obstacle and an excuse, then make progress.

Following Through

Protagonists leaning toward college understand that it's a long commitment, though following through on a conviction is hardly a challenge for people with this personality type. They recognize that time spent toward self-improvement isn't an exercise in narcissism, especially if it provides them with the credentials necessary for entering a helping profession that delivers good to humanity, or a complex intellectual and moral framework for handling the personal or global problems they long to solve.

When taking a balanced approach, Protagonists embrace the idea that college isn't an abdication of responsibility but an acceptance of it – if time there is used effectively. On the opposite side, Protagonists who don't seek out college can still find ways to advance their goals. Even a humble job in the service industry can be meaningful if they find satisfaction in a community of coworkers and customers. It can also support them financially while they volunteer for a social cause as their "true" career, especially if the skills developed during their volunteer work make them more viable candidates for positions in the nonprofit sector.

With this acceptance, Protagonists dedicate themselves to challenging but necessary coursework while maintaining themselves with much-needed relaxation. They balance their time and energy between the self-respect gleaned from a powerful mission and what's needed to make them happy in the moment.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Eternal Waiting

Protagonists can develop the unhealthy habit of spending their whole lives waiting for the perfect opportunity to arrive. The period after high school is a time of exceptional personal consequence, and younger Protagonists can allow the weightiness of decisions to become unbalanced, exaggerate it in their minds, and sink to inaction. There's something better right around the corner, they may think, while letting opportunity after opportunity pass them by. Their intuition, though a powerful tool, can work against them as they imagine a perfectly formed solution falling into their lap.

This combination of imagination and rumination manifests itself in Protagonists' inaction. They may wait for signs from the great unknown to dictate their next course of action – something that feels like the universe is specifically telling them to become an author or to go to XYZ University. They may spend more time trying to decide whether something *feels* right rather than taking the action needed to *make* it feel right. Protagonists who spend years agonizing over a course of study or path to employment eventually see that little was gained from the excessive deliberation, and perhaps much was lost.

Haunted Rumination

Choices that are later seen as "wrong" have a way of haunting people with this personality type. Living with choices is as necessary as making choices in the first place, but when Protagonists overanalyze not only future decisions but also decisions they've already made, this unbalanced view gives them little chance to develop the self-confidence or self-forgiveness to see them through.

What they may not realize is that rumination is a decision. It's a decision *not* to act and *not* to progress, which can cost far more time than school or a more intentional push into the professional world. Protagonists may be so afraid of making the wrong choice that they make no choice, instead falling onto a path that doesn't align with their personal values. Ten years hence, their regret is likely to be that they are no closer to their goals because they never acted.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

Adjusting Course

There is a fine line between deliberation and procrastination, and Protagonists need to work harder than most at distinguishing between the two. Once committed, they might refuse to modify a decision despite mounting evidence that's it's just not right for them, whatever their expectations may have been. This tendency toward delay stems from Protagonists' need to commit once they have chosen a course of action. But when nothing can be undone, the only choice is a well-considered decision. However, what counts as "well-considered" can be stretched to infinity. The question is whether this deliberation arises out of sensible caution or a fear of the unknown and a lack of the self-confidence needed to step into that abyss.

Protagonists should try to understand that few decisions are permanent. Changing their mind based on new information isn't only their prerogative, but a sign of maturity. Snap decision-making feels unnatural to Protagonists, but those who err a bit more on the side of rashness – at least compared to their usual resolution – may find that even when they make a wrong choice, the consequences are not nearly as irreversible as they had feared.

Here are some tips for Protagonists adjusting their educational course, as it's never too late to act:

- Request a tour of a local university.
- Visit an organization's or campus's website to look at the events calendar.

- Attend an orientation of a university or local college.
- Request an informational interview at an interesting company or non-governmental organization.

These actions require no commitment – and that's a good thing. Protagonists should feel no pressure to sign up for anything they don't find compelling. Hopefully, though, they will feel the rush of inspiration again and be off on another life chapter.

When Protagonists Choose College

Higher Education with Higher Purpose

Younger Protagonists who chafed against the curricula of high school will be pleased by the more diverse and inspired university environment. However, although the liberty of higher learning can be a boon to budding Protagonists, college can have its challenges. Protagonists who are lulled by the siren song of endless electives and roving Socratic discussions may be rudely awakened by far steeper expectations and workloads inherent in university endeavors. Not to say their expectations of college are illusory – Protagonists are likely to bloom into creative thought leaders. But first, they must conquer their expectations.

Nevertheless, bridging this gap propels Protagonists through life, and college can be an amenable staging ground for the battles to come. Their guiding spirit of principled rebellion, though misunderstood in the more rigid environs of high school, may serve them well in college, where they are likely to encounter professors and classmates who encourage precisely this type of pushback.

Balanced Approach to College

Understands Others

Protagonists may struggle to reconcile the utopian ideal of a university with the realities of campus life. Things that may disappoint and perhaps even confuse them are other people's general apathy toward learning and their emphasis on simply getting a good career. However,

Protagonists make it a point to try to understand others through communication and an open mind.

Protagonists who wish to understand others must remember that compromise is essential, even if it sometimes feels like politics. They needn't compromise their values, however. After all, the changes they strive for are usually social ones, and no movement for social evolution has rested entirely on the back of one person, no quest for equity on unilateral action. Forging alliances to broaden acceptance is an essential skill for Protagonists to master. Fortunately, they're excellent listeners, and if they learn to incorporate what they hear into what they say, they can build support for their ideas.

Learning Beyond Coursework

Protagonists enjoy classes within their discipline, but the same general education courses that left them cold in high school are no more compelling in their college incarnations, and they are just as much a requirement. Protagonists who summoned the discipline to conquer these obstacles during high school may have less trouble doing so now that they have at least the semblance of choice in the matter. They can intersperse less desirable courses throughout their degree program, pairing them with courses they enjoy to balance their course load.

Protagonists realize that the necessary and the desirable go together. They may roll their eyes at basic prerequisites like introductory composition, perhaps marveling at their peers' poor writing or shallow thinking, but what they must learn isn't determined by those peers. Protagonists recognize the value of their time and commit to learning what they can from basic and advanced studies alike by pushing themselves and being creative with opportunities, not by taking a syllabus at face value. They know that in every course, their education is in their own hands.

Unbalanced Approach to College

Weight of the World

Protagonists, when taking an unhealthy approach, pursue their studies with the weight of the world on their minds, an all-or-nothing attitude

that often exacerbates the pressures of mere academic performance. Such high expectations may press Protagonists to go beyond healthy means to succeed.

Aside from the financial burden that a lengthy college career can exact on Protagonists – whose academic debts might later force them into a profession that fulfills their fiscal needs while robbing them of their spirit – the mental toll shouldn't be underestimated, either. Even in the absence of family or work responsibilities (and students often have either or both), Protagonists in college who burn too brightly risk flaming out far too soon.

Focused Elsewhere

Protagonists may have several missions and responsibilities, and they are likely to devote their attention to areas where they're impassioned, even if it doesn't involve their coursework (especially less interesting coursework). People with this personality type may instead focus their attention exclusively on a charity they're volunteering for or a student organization they aim to lead one day. Although they still care about their coursework, it ranks low on their list of priorities and, at times, may be completely abandoned.

Such hyper-focus leads to a situation where they don't have the time to fulfill any of their responsibilities particularly well. They may spend so much time gathering information, campaigning, attending meetings or socials, or working on one thing that they leave no time for their higher education.

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Balancing the Burden

For Protagonists who feel restless in a purely academic environment, internships and volunteer work may bridge the gap, not only giving them the sense that they are already "being the change they wish to see in the world," but perhaps also shortening their post-college transition into that world. Protagonists can overburden themselves, though. A full course load is often more than enough to handle on its own, and although unpaid work may eventually lead to a more suitable career,

Protagonists who are simultaneously supporting themselves with a part-time (or full-time) job may not have the luxury of devoting their attention to anything more than what is already on their plate.

Though college should be taken seriously, Protagonists need not see everything they do as a matter of apocalyptic concern. Even they need to blow off steam, because refusing to make time for less mentally and emotionally taxing pursuits is a recipe for burnout. Aside from making sure they get out into nature or to a festival or fair from time to time, Protagonists may want to ensure that their course schedules always include a "fun" class, whether it directly relates to their chosen major or not. Here are steps for Protagonists who want to let loose without any guilt:

- Ask yourself, "Would I advise my friend to take a break every so often?"
- Set aside an hour every day that is dedicated solely to self-care.
    - This time should have nothing to do with personal development – no learning a new language, trying out computer programming, or volunteering for a cause. This time should be focused exclusively on relaxing your mind and body.
    - Don't do anything with this time that stresses you out.
    - Do something you wholeheartedly enjoy that doesn't feel like work (e.g., watching a guilty-pleasure TV show, taking a long and luxurious bubble bath).
- Schedule the rest of your time around that daily hour of self-care. Map out the rest of your schedule to distribute your work equally throughout the week so your self-care won't be eclipsed by cramming for a test the next morning.

Lifelong Learning

Lifelong learning goes beyond the rigors of school, though a return to academia is certainly an option. Older Protagonists who have embraced themselves fully are better able to give the benefit of the doubt to areas of study or schools of thought that might have struck them as irrelevant or worse in their younger years.

Forever Learning

Of all the personality types, Protagonists are among those who feel most comfortable with the prospect of lifelong learning, the notion that education isn't a thing one may possess, nor something one must get from some institution, but that it is instead a never-ending journey into the unknown. They know that their hunger for knowledge can never be truly fulfilled, just as their yen for justice can never be sated, and they find joy in that quest.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Finding Joy in Learning

Understanding the beauty in a clumsy first effort – like the beauty in a child's excitement when they first learn that red and yellow make orange – Protagonists pursue many things that too many people attempt only in childhood. They can do so because they grant themselves permission to find joy in their learning – a new instrument, art medium, or dance style, an unfamiliar sport or game, a distant campsite, or explorations in nature.

Many Protagonists, when content, continue to learn throughout their lives, not to prove something to someone, least of all themselves, but for the joy of trying something and getting better at it. They do something because it's fun, not because it serves some greater altruistic purpose (though that is by no means off-limits). Engaging the world around them with no agenda but curiosity and a light heart resonates with Protagonists' deeply cherished authenticity and is perhaps the greatest expression of what makes these individuals the people they are.

Enjoying Learning Over Improvement

Self-improvement is important, but enjoying oneself in the process is even more vital. Protagonists who decide to take a more balanced approach to lifelong learning attempt to appreciate the life they've developed for themselves, as well as praise themselves for the skills they have learned. By taking time to practice appreciation, Protagonists gain a certain self-awareness that lessens the fear that they're not learning anything at all, or that they're "stuck in the mud." They also

cultivate the ability to separate learning a new skill from needing to perform that skill *well* the first time around.

In fact, balanced Protagonists may separate learning new skills from their self-image completely. They feel accomplished when they succeed at something, but they don't base their self-worth upon what they have learned (or failed to learn). These Protagonists accept themselves as they are but also strive to learn when they can.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

Stubborn Worldviews

From an early age, Protagonists tend to formulate a cohesive set of opinions about the world. Those who refuse to adjust their ideas when appropriate find themselves lacking. They focus on subjects they already have an affinity for, rather than diversifying their learning, often pursuing knowledge that only supports their fundamental views. This limits their growth, perhaps even solidifies their ignorance, as they focus on one thing without truly having an open mind.

Some Protagonists recognize and compensate for their certitude, knowing that different perspectives bring forward different and equal truths about the world; unfortunately, others just allow their beliefs to congeal into an impenetrable ideological mass. This can conflict with their perception of themselves as fundamentally correct in their view of the world. While the world changes around them, these Protagonists may be reluctant to learn about new technologies, philosophies, or methods, always considering their own to be better than the rest.

Making the Magnificent the Mundane

Aside from the diminishing returns of a too-narrow focus, Protagonists who refuse to work at diversifying their learning and self-exploration risk growing weary of the very obsessions that once inflamed them. Their over-serious approach to knowledge robs them of the joy of learning and discovery. When they are unable to divert any attention from their mission, whether fixing the world's suffering or exercising their moral purity, the pure pleasure of a day off to learn a light-hearted skill becomes perverse and selfish in their eyes.

This unrelenting, adamant nature can hold Protagonists back as powerfully as it once propelled them forth. Once just one strong argument away from changing the world, those suffering a severe case of burnout may be equally certain that no such argument exists – or if one does, it's everyone else who's too stubborn and apathetic to make it. Early cynicism has its disadvantages, but late-blooming cynicism that grips the heart of an older Protagonist can be particularly devastating. With nothing to replace their former passion, they can quickly become despondent, so certain are they that every alternative course was ruled out in their youth.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Broadening Scope

The goals that Protagonists pursue are often so grand that they can consume their lives – and many see little reason to avoid that. Any sacrifice in the service of such ideals seems a small price to pay for the good they can do. As discussed earlier, this point of view can easily grow exaggerated and often unhealthy.

Protagonists spend their formative years becoming an authority in their chosen ideal, but as they mature, they might find at least some of their time better spent attaining a greater breadth of knowledge. A seemingly unrelated topic could yield fresh insight into their principal area of concern.

Being "set in your ways" isn't inherently bad. However, there's always room to improve upon an existing routine. Protagonists can begin by exploring the merits of a contrary opinion rather than sticking to what they already know. Here are some steps they can follow:

- Rather than immediately dismissing an argument, choose to take time to understand the other side. Consider:
  - How your own stance may appear to others.
  - Some benefits of what the other side is proposing.
- "Try on" the contrary opinion for a few minutes; during a debate or discussion, try switching roles with a person who holds an opposing view.

- Based on what you learn, adjust your opinion or viewpoint.

There are always new experiences to have and new things to learn. They don't have to be disruptive or life-changing. Once they rediscover joy in learning something new, they might choose to stretch their experiences even more. They may find that the benefit of continued learning far outweighs any risk.

Connecting the Mundane to the Magnificent

Protagonists' greatest peril is that learning can become a joyless process, because they have a tendency to get carried away with the scope of learning new things. If they are practicing the violin, for example, they may wonder, "How can I possibly compare to a master violinist? There's just so far to go." Learning stops being fun and seems burdensome.

To rebalance, however, Protagonists can connect the mundane to make it magnificent once more. Rather than being something they ruminate upon, learning can become an opportunity to reconnect with friends, family, and community. Such reconnections are what make humanity beautiful, and that upwelling of pure positive emotion can breathe new life into the darkest struggles. Simple mindfulness exercises are a good way to do this:

- Find an object to focus on (a plant, a cup, a body of water).
- Take a few minutes to focus on the object's simplest aspects: its colors, textures, scents, physical features.

This simple exercise takes only about five minutes, but it can pull Protagonists out of a bad head space and into the reality around them as they focus on what's in front of them in the moment.

Conclusion

Life Is Learning

Education means a lot of different things to a lot of people. For Protagonists, it's a way to advance their goals in life to help protect and serve others. But it can be so much more if given a chance. Protagonists' challenge is not so much in the hard work of learning. It's more about managing expectations and finding a reasonable pace so that learning

does not become a soulless drudgery or an overwhelming burden, but a rewarding experience that adds to life. For Protagonists, balance involves blending their determination and heart with pragmatism and realistic expectations – a balance that is quite achievable.

They can achieve balance by taking time to meet their own needs, setting plausible expectations for themselves, focusing on finding meaning and merit in the mundane, understanding that an A+ doesn't equate self-worth, and allowing themselves room to fail and to be wrong, celebrating failures right alongside their accomplishments as learning opportunities.

People are never solely balanced or unbalanced. All of us go back and forth, evolving and devolving. Balance is more akin to seasons as they come and go but always repeat. The trees become taller, people become wiser, all of us advancing in our way. Progress comes when we learn how to deal with the seasons, and it is an extension of the personal growth journey.

Professional Development

Because Protagonists are such a driven personality type, one of their primary challenges is finding a career that's in line with their ideals in a world that may not often share them. Although many careers are well-suited for this type, analyzing the different aspects of any job can help them find a professional role that speaks to their personal values, strengths, and goals.

Throughout this section, we will discuss how understanding their traits can help Protagonists excel in their professional development. We will examine what may frustrate them or create imbalance, as well as how they can use their strengths to regain balance and thrive in their careers. We hope this guide will give Protagonists the understanding and perspective needed to use their abilities to forge a fulfilling career path.

Jobs and General Skills

Career Options

We're talking about professional development to help Protagonists gain a deeper understanding of the role their personality type plays in finding and excelling in their chosen careers. Vocational and personal growth are interwoven, and they take place across all stages of life, from early education through retirement. Gaining increased self-understanding – by discovering values, goals, strengths, and weaknesses – is an important consideration for Protagonists and helps them decide on a career path and the best means of following it.

People with this personality type do their best work when their jobs combine creativity, compassion, and opportunities to take on challenges. Teaching, psychology, and social work are a few examples of careers that combine these traits, but Protagonists can shine in many fields. They are unlikely to feel comfortable in strictly impersonal roles or those with extensive rules.

With freedom comes responsibility, but Protagonists shouldn't be afraid to explore all their choices. It's unlikely that someone with this type will have difficulty coping with obligations – Protagonists' tactical preference for Judging keeps them on track, and their Extraversion helps them face the unknown with relish.

The Career Search

In the following sections, we will discuss how Protagonists can make the best use of their assets to find a suitable career and succeed in it. This includes ways they can excel in their job search, how to understand and develop their workplace habits, and tips for communicating effectively with managers and coworkers based on their personality types. We will also outline some specific professions Protagonists might consider. This is by no means a comprehensive list, but it provides some insight about the role that personality type plays in choosing an ideal career.

Suitable Career Options for Protagonists

Let's look at some fields that are likely to align with Protagonists' ideals and strengths. We won't offer a full list of professions, as too many choices would make our coverage both unwieldy and inadequate, and the list would grow longer daily. Instead, we will offer a sampling consistent with Protagonists' personality traits, with explanations about what makes them suitable.

Keep in mind that this isn't a firm prescription of what Protagonists must do to find success or happiness. Rather, we hope it provides some insight as they decide on their own. For Protagonists already employed, this may serve as an explanation of why they're happy or unhappy where they are. "What do I want to do for a living?" is a good starting point for many types – but for Protagonists trying to forge their

future, important questions when searching for a career include, "What can give me meaning, purpose, and joy?" "What do I want to be?" and "What problems do I want to solve?"

Careers with Meaning

Protagonists love to find meaning in their work through connections with people, inspiring others and helping them grow. This need to nurture others makes careers in health care rewarding for them. However, what counts as "meaningful work" is subjective, and individual Protagonists may be able to blend their principles into almost any honest job. Although some careers well-suited to typical Protagonist traits are listed in the following sections, it's by no means a restrictive list.

Protagonists can satisfy their nurturing impulses in many ways outside the helping and educational professions. While working as grocers, for example, they can help direct customers toward healthy, delicious food, changing their lives for the better. For Protagonists, meaning comes from engaging challenges head-on with bold idealism and connecting to people with energetic, considerate care. They can do this anywhere they wish.

Utilize Creativity and Insight

Not only do Protagonists need their careers to provide meaning, but they also yearn to express themselves creatively. They may have difficulty in jobs where they aren't allowed to let their ingenuity blossom. Jobs where they can use their insights to effect real change in others' lives bring them the most satisfaction. For Protagonists, money and Employee of the Month awards can't compare to a life of values and principles brought into reality through creative and fearless action.

Therefore, Protagonists may find it hard to meet their needs in corporate environments that force them to manage practical policies that favor profits over ethics or human cost. Management does not always recognize or reward creativity in places where paperwork and handbooks overshadow personal expression. So, people with the Protagonist personality type often express independence by finding flexible leadership positions or starting their own businesses.

Combining Personal and Professional Growth

Using their drive for personal growth to advance their professional lives – and, in turn, their professional lives to develop their personal growth – is often the most rewarding part of Protagonists' careers. They're drawn to positions where they can make a significant difference, and they aren't afraid of competition, pressure, or responsibility. Many other types strive for materialistic or egoistic career goals such as an enviable salary, an impressive title, or a specific number of subordinates. These goals alone aren't enough for Protagonists.

For people with this personality type, professional growth is about cultivating skills and understanding – within themselves and their teams. Even if they try to convince themselves that they should aim for more typical rewards, deep down they'll always sense that they can do better. This makes it difficult for Protagonists to fall into a rut – and that's great news for everyone. People with this personality type have the capacity to achieve great things when they put their determined idealism to work.

Recognized as elegant communicators, Protagonists often aim for expressive careers in creative areas like writing blogs, stories, and screenplays. Music, photography, design, and art are reasonable alternatives, as well. They allow Protagonists to focus on deeper themes of personal growth, morality, and spirituality. By developing their craft with new approaches and perspectives, Protagonists often shine a light on society's flaws and expose their own for all to see.

Health Care

Counseling, psychology, and medicine speak to two of Protagonists' key motivators: compassion and a sense of purpose. People with this personality type gravitate toward growth and self-development, which are the hallmarks of those fields. Protagonists also enjoy helping others gain insight into and control over their lives, and positions in these disciplines offer these Extraverted types opportunities to use their social skills while working with their clients or patients.

Protagonists' impressive charisma and strong sense of purpose often make them inspiring figures to those in need of mental, physical, or spiritual healing. With their dedication and personal convictions,

they are very well-suited to positions where they care for and guide others, and they revel in such work, treating it as a sacred duty. When Protagonists can lead others into a better life, they feel rewarded and their value confirmed.

Some job examples include:

- Alcohol- and drug-addiction counselor
- Marriage counselor
- Psychiatrist (with an emphasis on psychotherapy)
- Psychologist
- Social worker
- Physician
- Nurse practitioner
- Physician's assistant
- Career counselor
- Religious worker
- Healthcare administrator (if allowed to pursue a vision)

Education

Growth and learning are central to Protagonists' approach to the world, so teaching and working with students suit them well. Imaginative Protagonists connect with younger students using their energy and empathy. With older students, they provide an idealistic perspective and present their subject with passion and creativity, especially if they teach the humanities. With adult learners, Protagonists are inspirational, connecting to their students with respect and wisdom.

Regardless of who they teach, Protagonists are keen on treating their students as individuals with distinct traits and needs. As Extraverts, they find constant contact with students and colleagues throughout the day energizing, enjoying both the social give-and-take as well as the sense that they're changing lives for the better.

Protagonists' interest is in the uniqueness of their students as people, though they may regard standardized tests and other tools as having some potential. They do well as administrators or in other leadership roles as well, bringing their determined vision to the overarching structure of their institutions. As with health care, they do better as visionary, creative leaders rather than strictly practical ones. Such jobs can include:

- Preschool, elementary, or high school teacher
- College lecturer (especially in religion, philosophy, or literature)
- Adult-education teacher
- School principal (but mostly as a visionary)
- Guidance counselor
- School psychologist
- Religious educator

Public and Social Work

Protagonists thrive on values-based causes and the pursuit of justice in the purest sense. They're at their best when chasing some larger truth. Other types might choose a career in law for the challenge of winning, the thrill of finding solutions, the rush of making a great argument, the drama, the power, the fame, and the fortune. However, those enticements alone don't seduce Protagonists. Although they may appreciate exciting legal challenges, Protagonists are more likely to practice law to ensure that values are upheld, and society becomes a bit fairer.

Law is not the only profession that helps them pursue such goals. Any chance to create a better, more equitable world gives Protagonists professional meaning. Protagonists' ideals are their underlying motivation, but their understanding of how people work and fit into a larger context, not to mention their steady determination, makes them potent agents of change. Combining well-organized thoughts with a broad vision often creates arguments so robust that all but the most unreasonable opponents end up agreeing with them.

This way of thinking helps in several jobs well-suited to people with this personality type:

- Lawyer (especially at not-for-profit firms)
- Diplomat or liaison
- Local political representative
- Investigative journalist
- Novelist or blogger

Challenging Career Paths

Exploring personality types is helpful in steering people in the right career directions, but this is by no means prescriptive. There are likely hundreds of examples of individuals who don't fit the mold and are happy in jobs conventional wisdom would suggest otherwise. "Challenging" here refers to typically not compatible, but of course some can find fulfillment in jobs that are unusual for their type. It's rare for people to get everything they want out of their work lives, and trade-offs often come into play. The following describes typical challenges for Protagonists in the job market.

Disheartened by Routine and Pressure

Protagonists fall flat in work that focuses on impersonal concerns, is mundane, or involves heartless conflict. Accounting, auditing, data analysis, and similarly grinding, data-heavy work easily leaves Protagonists fidgety and unfulfilled. They need "warm-blooded" work, filled with humans and human potential.

The core problem that Protagonists face is that the knowledge underpinning the passion takes time to build. Likely, their first few professional roles will involve a fair amount of mundane, uninspiring work. Ideas, cues, meaning, and self-realization are supreme for Protagonists on the job. Unfortunately, finding them in the soulless grind of grunt work is difficult at best. In such situations, Protagonists can still benefit by building inspiring and useful human connections.

Difficulty Choosing a Career

Protagonists find that many corporate career paths aren't designed for them, but rather those motivated by status and financial gain. Not that making a healthy living and receiving respect are somehow wrong, but such rewards are often compensation for a lack of more fulfilling work. Protagonists need something more than a paycheck and prestige.

This doesn't mean that Protagonists have difficulty seeing choices. In fact, they're likely to face the opposite problem – many Protagonists struggle to begin a career early on because they see 10 wildly different paths forward, each with its own intrinsic rewards. Such choices are alluring, but they can also be heartbreaking because each decision means abandoning many other possibilities.

Cold, Repetitive, or Data-Driven Work

Protagonists need their positions to have a personal touch and prefer to focus on the human (or the humane). Factory or data-entry jobs are not a good fit, as work revolving around some*thing* rather than some*one* just leaves Protagonists unfulfilled. They need work that has "soul." Their work must feel purposeful and creative, so repetitive tasks, in general, are unappealing to Protagonists, and social isolation leaves them bored at best.

It's important to point out here, however, that some fields – among them, science, technology, engineering, and mathematics – have a reputation as coldly rational and excessively data-driven. Although they're technical and data focused, many careers in these fields also require creativity and insight, and their goal often is to make the world a better place.

Protagonists can bring a compassionate approach to some of the global issues that these fields address. Their Intuitive trait can prove valuable when they are forming ideas and engaging in expansive problem-solving, and their Extraversion can enable them to share a group's vision in compelling and effective ways.

Loose Principles or Unclear Values

Protagonists struggle in any industry that doesn't have clear social responsibilities, even more so if they believe the work might be doing

harm to others. Businesses revolving around vices, such as casinos, can leave many Protagonists feeling guilty. Seemingly neutral work like investing or managing money may feel shady to Protagonists if they sense the business somehow takes advantage of others or is part of some greater systemic problem.

Even in otherwise ideal roles like mentorship or charitable outreach, Protagonists feel uncomfortable if the company they work for has earned a bad reputation with its behavior, such as misuse of funds. Protagonists need to consider whether management's values align with their own. They need a company culture that values integrity and reliability in the service of something they support before they can settle into a job, regardless of the position.

No Social Time

It's important that Protagonists have many opportunities to engage with others. Their Extraverted and Feeling natures create a deep need to interact with others to feel fulfilled, in both their personal and professional lives. Work that separates Protagonists from other people leaves them feeling starved, though they may continue such a job anyway if it serves their ideals.

Although they have the discipline to excel anywhere they choose, Protagonists' greatest ideas and accomplishments often occur when they can put a human face on their motivation. Roles that allow them to feel as though their work will positively affect other people can help them continue their effort even when they are working alone. Nonetheless, they'll have far greater energy when social contact is a part of the job.

Career Alternatives

The traditional path is not for everyone. With their resourcefulness and ingenuity, many Protagonists often wander into unexpected career directions. In this section, we'll explore alternatives to the conventional job market.

Self-Employment

People don't need regular jobs to live comfortably. We live in an age of possibilities, and selling one's time to a corporation isn't the only way to earn money. The working world has changed radically, and spending multiple decades at the same job is no longer the norm. Outside a few specialized fields such as medicine and the military, long-term employment contracts with retirement benefits are atypical.

So, working independently may be a better choice for some Protagonists. Self-employment has many benefits, such as the ability to plan one's own time, the tangible results of one's work, and, of course, self-direction. Protagonists value autonomy and creative freedom; being their own boss gives them such opportunities. Furthermore, self-employment solves one of the major hurdles that Protagonists are likely to face in a corporate environment – forced loyalty to questionable practices and ideals.

Many creative fields allow self-employed Protagonists to make a living, such as photography, graphic design, interior design, freelance writing, information technology, website design, and translation services. Hobbies and pastimes often translate into self-employment opportunities.

Professional Volunteer

A daring and inspiring alternate career choice for Protagonists is that of professional volunteer – making income second to the larger goals of changing the world. Although unlikely to lead to financial prosperity, this path offers unparalleled personal satisfaction. If supported by income from other sources (perhaps part-time work, family, a partner, or a spouse), Protagonists who devote themselves to matters of conscience and human development can move mountains. In addition, this is an option they can transition into later in life, bringing skills from previous occupations into the nonprofit world.

If Protagonists want to offer such help, the least developed countries are hungry for compassion, dedication, and helping hands, and any skills and knowledge can be of use. A résumé of abilities with a passionate cover letter may allow Protagonists to enter many different organizations as volunteers. If they can accept a potentially austere material life, the rewards to the soul are endless.

However, foreign aid work and a monastic lifestyle aren't mandatory – many volunteer opportunities are available closer to home. Administrative and fund-raising roles abound at the headquarters of any idealistic organization, from grassroots political groups to religious and secular charities. They appreciate the willing minds, hearts, and voices of enthusiastic Protagonists who want to pitch in.

Getting on the Career Ladder

Now that we've discussed many career paths that may be suitable for Protagonists, we will look at how people with this personality type can approach their job search. In this section, we will touch on contacting prospective employers, making a résumé stand out, and preparing for an interview.

Although applying to and interviewing for jobs can be stressful, Protagonists' excellent communication skills and ability to approach subjects they care about with clear dedication and passion tend to make them appealing candidates. Their charm and social skills are likely to be an asset.

Making Contact

Thanks to their inherent ability to connect with others and the natural influence that arises from it, Protagonists usually have a good idea of how to approach prospective employers in the right way. Their intuition is a powerful tool. Mapping out potential networks, crafting introductory emails, and presenting themselves in a positive light – these come naturally to Protagonists, and they shouldn't hesitate to use such strengths.

Protagonists are convincing and have the strategic thinking and imagination necessary to develop a very personal approach. One compelling email sent to the right person is often much more impactful than hundreds of random, cookie-cutter applications. When Protagonists take the time to research the companies they're applying to, they begin to imagine themselves in those positions. When they start drafting their cover letters, it's as though they already belong, and it shows.

Of course, Protagonists need to be able to present their skills in the right way to distinguish themselves from other candidates – these types

shine in creative, collaborative work. The buzzwords "excellent people skills" have become such an inseparable part of job requirements that stressing such competencies in interviews is a must. Protagonists thrive in bustling groups that are trying to make important things happen. Being able to express this skill honestly, rather than using buzzwords for their own sake, makes an impression in the organizations Protagonists appreciate most.

Relating Outside Interests

Not all companies think to ask, but organizations rarely want employees with no life outside work. Protagonists can take some time to think about what hobbies could be somewhat applicable to prospective employers and then find a way to turn those ideas into real-life projects. Opportunities abound – they can engage in competitions or volunteer projects, build an online presence (e.g., a blog), or travel. Such activities appeal to Protagonists anyway, and if becoming a more appealing candidate is part of the inspiration to do something exciting and worthwhile, so be it.

The projects don't necessarily have to involve the same skills that potential jobs would. In whatever way Protagonists can show that they're able creators, they can refer to those successes on their résumés. Not only does this make Protagonists more attractive and versatile candidates, but it gives them breathing space in their interviews. Answering certain interview questions such as, "Describe a situation where you used your problem-solving skills," is much easier with a list of successful projects ready to be cited.

Protagonists are often eloquent speakers and presenters, and they can develop an online profile to make the job hunt easier. Employers often Google prospective candidates or check out links included in résumés. An applicant may get some bonus points if their résumé highlights a hobby such as writing a blog about a specific field.

Preparing for the Interview

Protagonists' enthusiasm and dedication are usually clearly visible when they are competing for a job they're passionate about. In an interview, Protagonists can focus on discussing the prospective job as an intensely personal interest and highlight the role they want to play in

it. People with this personality type become even more diplomatic and charming as time goes by, so they don't have any difficulties moving such conversations along.

Despite their inherent communication skills, Protagonists may want to spend some time preparing their presentations. Even their excellent natural abilities can be "tuned up." Before an interview, they might find themselves daydreaming about the implications of the work they'll do once they get the job, while forgetting to prepare for the nuts and bolts of the interview itself. This is a trap people with the Intuitive trait can fall into.

Protagonists need to be aware of the most common interview techniques and questions, so they aren't caught off-guard by something like, "What's your biggest weakness?" Answering with "perfectionism" and "I work too hard" may be honest responses, but they're also familiar enough to be clichés. When interviewers are looking for self-awareness and introspection, these responses cut off any opportunities to offer deeper answers.

Protagonists should prepare to answer many template questions, especially in the early stages of a job search, with something approaching enthusiasm. Sometimes recruiters don't even know much about the positions themselves and are simply going through a checklist. If Protagonists go in expecting that, they can be ready to put unique and memorable spins on even the most routine questions.

Protagonists in the Workplace

After the contracts are signed, after Protagonists settle into their jobs and serve as exemplary employees – then what? How can they progress in their careers while staying true to themselves, and what difficulties

are they likely to face? In the following paragraphs, we'll discuss Protagonists' possible paths forward.

Balanced Workplace Habits

Practicing Leadership

Protagonists can be excellent team managers who bring people together. They instinctively know how to promote goals and motivate colleagues, defusing conflicts and building group cohesion. Individuals with this personality type care about the feelings of those in the workplace, and they try to get to know everyone, seeking to understand what drives and inspires their coworkers.

With Protagonists' outgoing nature and their ability to grasp the big picture, they can layer inspiration on top of any other practical skills they may have. Willing to take the lead, they go beyond simple tasks, preferring instead to conduct missions of a grander scale, and they usually don't need to hold a formal leadership title to influence those around them. Their friendly enthusiasm, vision, and charisma put them out front regardless of job title.

Authentic Creators

Protagonists are likely to find innovative ways to look at their work and authentically creative paths to succeeding in their jobs. Even though they are too interested in harmony and the welfare of others to be very rebellious, they are, nonetheless, always thinking about doing a better job. They are willing to try more unorthodox means, and they think doing so is in everyone's best interest. They are not necessarily rule-breakers, but they are creative enough that they might find themselves challenging the status quo or at least suggesting many improvements to it.

If Protagonists are asked to follow a script or procedure manual without adding their own spin, they are likely to feel unfulfilled. All roads lead to growth for Protagonists; for them, that means developing their creative influence and being able to add it to any endeavor. Anything less feels like drudgery and a rejection of the potential they believe is within them. Fortunately, innovative thinking is likely to be an attractive quality in the modern job market.

Unbalanced Workplace Habits

The Problem of the Compassionate Worker

Protagonists avoid the allure of power and rarely strive for leadership roles, but their charisma, organizational skills, and vision often place them there. They may not be comfortable in a hierarchal position or may even reject a formal title. But they commonly lead anyway. Sometimes their leadership is from a lateral position rather than from a higher, formal one. And when they lead, their approach to life can cause them difficulties as they balance the objectivity an influencer needs against their appreciation for compassion.

Protagonists are prone to getting emotionally involved. They find it difficult to be impersonal and detached, and the emotional troubles of coworkers or subordinates affect Protagonists deeply, without some healthy shielding of their emotions. Empathy, in its raw form, is positive; but empathy without acknowledging the bigger picture can be difficult in the workplace.

In a broader way, Protagonists focus on the greater good but also struggle to tolerate an "ends justify the means" attitude. Though productive, they usually dislike an impersonal, results-oriented approach. Nonetheless, "results" are a business reality, so they may always struggle to balance their ideologies against productivity. This can create a series of tensions that Protagonists may need to directly address. However, they also dislike conflict, believing there is always a way to keep all parties happy through understanding, compromise, and integrity. Their efforts to strive for such harmony further complicate any efforts toward evening out the demands of leadership, productivity, and the Protagonist heart.

Stubbornly Creative

Protagonists excel in roles where they can help other people grow and develop, both within and outside their organization, while still staying faithful to their principles. This ideological stance demands a degree of independent and creative thought, but when Protagonists lose perspective, they may protect their own ideas too vigorously. Their normal tolerance toward the opinions and standards of others may suffer during such times.

Although Protagonists suppress negative feelings almost by instinct, when they are insecure, they can be quick to show displeasure, with a black-and-white approach to their passions. If the organization they're working in helps them manage these traits, Protagonists have no difficulties progressing in their career. If the company has a less-than-ideal mission statement or a purely dog-eat-dog culture, however, Protagonists struggle to square their ideals with such thinking and may need to find another position.

Rebalancing Workplace Habits

Learning to Compartmentalize

To prevent focus on the wrong issues, Protagonists may want to fine-tune their need to be involved with others. Constant conflict with managers, who will likely become more resistant to that conflict over time, can make further moves in their career difficult. People with this personality type often sacrifice their needs, wishes, or workplace accomplishments to help others, but moderation is key if they want to succeed. Protagonists set themselves up to do more good for those they care about if they can prioritize business only when it's truly necessary.

Learning to fit different work roles at different times and in different situations is a skill that leads to professional success. If people limit themselves to one role, the powers-that-be may even consider them limited in a more general way and doubt their usefulness. Protagonists will likely never lose their compassionate cores. Without fear of becoming something they don't want to become, they can confidently try out other roles, in effect complementing their central personality traits. They can be both a caring person and a results-oriented worker without inner conflict.

The follow exercise may help Protagonists get a better sense of what it means to enjoy varied roles while remaining true to their values and core characteristics:

- On an index card or small piece of paper, list across the top all the roles you play in an average day. For example: student, parent,

employee, manager, housekeeper, family finance manager, driver, lawn maintenance person. Include at least five.

- Draw a column under each role. For an entire day, each time you play one of the roles on the card, put a tick mark in the column.
- At the end of the day, review the tick marks. How many different roles did you play in a day? At the end of the day, did it make you a different person?

Learning to compartmentalize and vary their roles and views of themselves can help Protagonists more fully grasp that sometimes empathy is the key to effectiveness, but other times a more objective style is needed. Sometimes a job might call for a compassionate leader. Other times, it might call for a practical money manager. Appreciating the flexibility needed to move among various roles can help Protagonists better navigate the workplace.

Restoring Openness

Secure people usually don't spend much time defending themselves and their own ways. When Protagonists are stubbornly creative, it is likely that they feel a threat to some or all their three core growth motivators: self-confidence, self-respect, and self-esteem.

Protagonists' natural inclination is to be open to and encouraging of others. Oppositional behavior tends to make them uncomfortable, and that discomfort can signal a need for self-evaluation – typically a loud signal. When these types resist someone else's suggestions, they may have to review their motivations: Do they oppose the ideas because they believe they are right? Or are they defiant to protect the things that give them value and assurance? If the latter, is there a real assault they need to protect themselves from? Or do they, perhaps, need to build themselves up in other ways? An exercise to test their thinking:

- Watch or listen to a news program and list 10 or more things you can disagree with while watching.
- Make three columns on a piece of paper. Label them:
  1. "I disagree because they are wrong, and I can prove it."
  2. "I disagree on some gut level that I can't explain."

3. "I disagree because of my basic values, which I can explain."

- Place the items you disagree with in the appropriate columns. Highlight those you perceive as threatening to your values or your beliefs in any way.
- Simply making yourself aware of the reasons you might disagree with something can be enlightening.

Workplace Cooperation Between Types

Much of who people are at work is revealed through how they interact with others. This section explores professional pairings between Protagonists and each of the four type groups. It includes brief reviews of collaborative traits and potential obstacles, as well as some tips that may help them navigate the tricky waters their similarities or differences may create. Efforts are inevitably more productive when members of a staff recognize the many gifts various personality types offer one another, and they find positive ways to thrive together in the workplace.

Protagonist–Analyst Cooperation

Balanced Protagonist–Analyst Cooperation

Big Ideas

Neither Analysts nor Protagonists like to deal with details, though Analysts like the *idea* of details. Both prefer to deal with the big picture instead, absorbing knowledge almost subconsciously and then incorporating it into a larger constellation of Intuitive understanding. They're both imaginative and creative, connecting the dots in often deep ways. This compatibility and love for the more abstract give them plenty of common ground.

Protagonists and Analysts both like to work with ideas. Their imaginations manipulate their ideas into models. They differ in their area of interest: Protagonists create ideal designs for a perfect society or the perfect workforce, whereas Analysts create excellent schemes for a system. Analysts show interest in efficiency, whereas Protagonists show interest in humanity. When balanced, they recognize and accept each other's focus while sharing their contributions freely with an organization, and they can achieve much together.

Compassion and Efficiency

Protagonists live in a world of values, ideals, and compassion. Analysts are more comfortable with structures and puzzles. Both share strong views.

Analysts often allow efficiency to outweigh empathy. Protagonists add to Analysts' offerings by bringing humanity to the forefront. Protagonists understand and even share strict standards, but they also provide "soul" to any system that Analysts devise or innovate. However, an organization only about love, peace, and harmony can get a little mushy around the edges. Rational analysis is an essential ingredient for an organization to grow and prosper. This is where Analysts contribute most.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Analyst Cooperation

Consumed by Debate

Although Protagonists and Analysts can use their different foci in complementary ways, their differences can create conflict. Analysts can be critical of Protagonists' views and consider them too soft, whereas Protagonists might regard Analysts' views as insensitive and without concern for higher values. Agree or disagree, they can end up on opinionated tangents together, effectively shutting out more level and practical types like Sentinels and Explorers, who are more interested in getting the job done.

Protagonists and Analysts working together may spend significant time debating their different approaches in the workplace. Analyst managers might argue that it would be more efficient to replace the receptionist at the front desk with a touch-screen computer, highlighting the time and

money saved. Protagonist managers in the same office would probably bemoan the sterile approach and the disregard for the employee. They may wonder about the welfare of the receptionist, criticize the lack of human warmth involved in greeting visitors with a machine, or go further by rejecting any steps toward a society in which human effort is expendable.

Shared Impatience

Analysts can be blunt and impatient with people who don't see certain points their way. Protagonists can be similar, if for different reasons. Protagonists' idealism may cause them to become combative as well, if Analysts come on too strong and won't give ground.

Perhaps most damaging, Protagonists might not let disagreements go if they see Analysts' attitudes as habitual tyranny. Analysts, on the other hand, may be dismissive of the "soft" approach, possibly further infuriating sincere Protagonists. Protagonists might then extend the conflict for lengthy periods of time, stubbornly seeking justice.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Analyst Cooperation

Speaking Analysts' Language

Protagonists find willing conversation partners and allies when they begin to ask Analysts "why" questions and maintain a willingness to explore their views on issues such as workplace organization. Perhaps most importantly, Protagonists can shed (or at least set aside) their fear of asking their Analyst coworkers for clarification when they're confused by an idea or comment. This also gives Protagonists a chance to make a counterargument. It's not that Analysts disdain the human side of things – sometimes they just forget to consider it.

Analysts are pleasantly surprised by individuals who are interested enough in furthering their understanding by asking them to explain their opinions or comments. They even like when someone challenges them – but only if it grows the discussion and is not too excessive.

Conversely, Protagonists respect and appreciate coworkers who understand the noble intentions beneath their calculated efforts. When

it comes to occupational issues, they're more interested in getting their thoughts and ideas across than making friends; ironically, they often make friends with those who are receptive to that approach, such as Analysts.

A quick guide to what Protagonists need to know to communicate better with Analysts:

- Recognize your differences. Although you have much in common, your perspectives can be markedly dissimilar.
- Adopt a "why" rather than "who" approach. That doesn't mean Analysts totally disregard the "who." It just falls a little lower on their list of primary concerns.
- Ask for further explanations to reveal an Analyst's rational framework. Don't be afraid to challenge them a little when it's appropriate.
- The lack of a warm demeanor does not necessarily mean a lack of respect or a lack of appreciation. Don't assume a contentious relationship exists simply based on an emotionally cold presentation.

Protagonists are not enemies of Analysts' rationality. Powerful results are possible when Protagonists choose to focus on shared interests rather than differences.

Speaking Protagonists' Language

Protagonists can help Analysts understand how to communicate with them by promoting questions and statements that include "who," rather than just "why" or "how." The more time they take to understand their Protagonist coworkers, the more likely Analysts are to learn what ideals and values propel people with this personality type. In doing so, they can gain a more nuanced understanding of how Protagonists approach work.

Protagonists can also moderate their reactions when confronted with challenging opinions from Analysts. Two sharp minds with different perspectives can combine their ideas in productive ways and develop collaborative results. Protagonists may come to understand the value of a purely tactical approach, and Analysts may eventually see the energetic efficiency created when people work in harmony together.

A quick guide to help Protagonists and Analysts speak the same language:

- While being sensitive to each other's differences, remember that neither approach is superior to the other. Proper balance requires both parties to be sensitive to the basic traits of the other while being assertive (not aggressive) in presenting ideas.
- A "yes, and ..." approach sometimes helps. "*Yes*, I understand the need to increase daily productivity, *and* we need to make sure that our coworkers have enough breaks and balance in their day, so they can give their best." Try not to directly oppose ideas; instead, *add* information and alternate perspectives.
- Show Analysts how your goals are the same (for example, caring for clients and employees can help a company meet its objectives and result in more profits).
- Gently remind Analyst coworkers that emotional expression and influences are not necessarily vacuous. Emotions carry their own rationality, and Analysts are likely to respect that if they understand how the two go together.

Protagonists are usually not shy about presenting their ideas. However, anybody can be intimidated by approaches that are not their own. When working with Analysts, they should remember that their point of view is as valid as the rational ideas Analysts present. Respectful assertion can make such relationships more productive.

Protagonist–Diplomat Cooperation

Balanced Protagonist–Diplomat Cooperation

Sharing the Same Language

Two Diplomats have the advantage of speaking the same language. Diplomats, including Protagonists, are visionaries who focus on growth

and humanity. When they talk, their discussions sometimes wander into areas others might see as impractical, but they usually have a significant purpose despite their sometimes-sparse attention to necessary details. Facts are essential, but they play a supporting role to the grander ideas so important to Diplomats.

Protagonists find ready conversation partners in other Diplomats, as they all enjoy discussing matters of principle. Other coworkers may discuss the nuts and bolts of an organization. Protagonists and Diplomats talk to each other about creating harmony and growth within a company, and they define success as individuals increasing their potential by committing to ambitions that exceed self-serving interests.

Idealistically Driven

Although they can appear excessively idealistic, Diplomats agree that a better way and better world are possible. Their values are important to them, driving their decisions and attitudes. Protagonists and their Diplomat colleagues can transform their transcendent discussions into action, but not all Diplomats are as action oriented as Protagonists. If Protagonists exercise their influence and natural leadership qualities, then they can help balance out the dreamy inaction of those who are less hands-on.

Such action, when shared by Diplomats, targets injustice or unfairness in a business, and Diplomat colleagues may form strong alliances around such matters. They're cause driven, and they understand each other when such problems arise. Protagonists and their Diplomat coworkers agree that a cold and calculating business that's willing to sacrifice or mistreat people to meet its goals needs fixing.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Diplomat Cooperation

An Overabundance of Guiding Principles

The problems Protagonists and other Diplomats may have when working with one another have nothing to do with understanding. However, they may have trouble if they become stuck in their style of thinking, inadvertently excluding the insights of those who think differently – especially if they've labeled certain types as thinking "conventionally."

In business and life, it's good to have varied personality types around to provide balance. Too many Diplomats brainstorming in one room may produce a great many guiding principles but few details that involve turning a profit in the process (which, regardless of appeal, is usually necessary to keep things running). They do well when it comes to mission statements or other visionary materials, but precise tactical planning may not be their strong point when their synergy is unbalanced.

Diplomats may even fall into the deeper trap of dismissing others' attempts to apply some practical realism to the process as merely "negative," regardless of the intent of such efforts. Although many consider inspirational goals an important launching pad toward the future, without a concrete "how-to" strategy, even willful Protagonists can find themselves struggling to move forward with their big ideas. Endless discussions about such matters can do more harm than good, and Diplomats may need perspective and a dose of reality from other personality groups.

When Ideas Dominate

Another issue for Protagonists and Diplomats is inaction. Because outgoing Protagonists usually choose to act on their ideas, they may become frustrated with other Diplomats, especially those who are strongly Introverted. Although empathetic, they can lose patience with those who merely talk about their feelings and ideas without applying bold action.

Protagonists are initially supportive of the imagination of other Diplomats, even sharing in it, but they naturally expect to subsequently externalize those ideas with hard work and dedication. "All talk and no action" is likely to try Protagonists' patience.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Diplomat Cooperation

Bring Details on Board

Learning to tap into other Diplomats' imagination and creativity is mutually rewarding. When Protagonists and their Diplomat coworkers dig deeply into each other's reservoirs of ideas and dreams, they can move idealistic mountains.

However, the Diplomat group contains many of the rarest personality types, often with outsider perspectives on the world. Voluntary committees can easily become cliques, and they may struggle to put ideas into real action. To avoid this:

- Consider inviting more practical types from other personality groups to the discussion. Perhaps a Sentinel (_SP_) can aid with logistics or an Analyst (_NT_) can put a more rational spin on the discussion.
- Set agendas for meetings with specific topics and time allotted for each topic to avoid meandering conversations. Agendas might include "old business" as well as "new business" to clear any distractions and establish continuity. Someone taking the role of secretary can be helpful.
- Implement a rule that each thing discussed must lead to a measurable action. For example, if the topic is worker morale, perhaps start by implementing an anonymous survey measuring employee satisfaction. Appoint a "sergeant-at-arms" to monitor and stress that measurable actions are required during meetings.

Although the exercise describes formal meetings, informal discussions can borrow from it. The more structured Protagonists and the Diplomat colleagues make any of their conversations, the more likely they are to lead to results.

Time to Think

Protagonists must give other Diplomats space to process material on their own. Diplomats must understand an idea before they're comfortable moving forward with it, especially when dealing with sensitive subjects or information. When they finally move forward, they thrive on appreciation.

Protagonists rarely have trouble here, but if they're frustrated or impassioned, they may let niceties fall by the wayside. And speaking up and sharing information do not come naturally to the Introverts in the group. Here are some suggestions to shift everyone's thinking in a more results-driven direction and to help preserve healthy conversation:

- Set deadlines. It's fine to take time to think, but too much time becomes an excuse for inaction. Make sure to cap the time for pondering ideas.

- Stay on task. Motivate each other so as not to get too lost in thought.
- Provide gentle encouragement to inspire each other to continue providing valuable contributions.
- Start with the end in mind: What do you hope your meeting or conversations might accomplish? Continually remind yourself of the goal to stay on track.

Taking time to map out thoughts on an issue is prudent. But like anything, balance is vital. Protagonists can shine here and help other Diplomats who engage in lengthy rumination move forward.

Protagonist–Sentinel Cooperation

Balanced Protagonist–Sentinel Cooperation

Standing for Others

Protagonists focus on ideological matters, whereas Sentinels concentrate on practical matters. But both find their joy in supporting others and protecting their welfare, leaving the two types much to talk about.

Sentinels might focus on completing the payroll and guaranteeing all receive their salaries, whereas Protagonists might work to ensure salaries are on par with the needs and efforts of the staff. Both derive energy and self-respect from contributing to the happiness and security of others. As a team, they address both the material and emotional needs of those affected by their work.

Spanning the Spectrum

For Protagonists, the big ideas are the most important. They're interested in growth. Anything that comes across as a "minor detail"

may feel unimportant to them, so they sometimes miss small but essential items. Sentinels don't, and organizations need their diligence to run smoothly. However, Sentinels can get so caught up in details and procedures that they lose the larger purpose of what they're doing.

Partnerships between Protagonists and Sentinels help them hold onto the greater vision of their organizations. This is especially true when it comes to issues like finding practical ways to support human capital. If both respect each other's strengths, they can form powerful teams, combining idealism with the know-how that makes it all work.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Sentinel Cooperation

Concrete and Abstract Perspectives

Protagonists' worldview comes from an almost subconscious linking of information and feelings, and they are always imagining something better. However, their ideas can be hard to convey in concrete, realistic terms. Sentinels protect efficiency and order by using accepted standards and methods. To have value to them, things must be proved. In a way, they try to connect working practices from the past with the needs of the present and future, hoping that will guarantee similar results.

Protagonists and Sentinels apply those same standards to their coworkers as well. Protagonists appreciate less tangible qualities like thoughtfulness and vision, regardless of proven skill, whereas Sentinels look to previous work performance – loyalty, seniority, and proven results are critical considerations for them in any workplace relationship. This can leave either or both feeling too judgmental to connect on a meaningful level, leading to a sense of non-cooperation in a workplace.

Judge Not

Sentinels might judge Protagonists as too ensconced in impractical ideas without concrete outcomes. Protagonists might judge Sentinels as too pedestrian or as lacking imagination. Treating Sentinels as somehow "generic" cuts Protagonists off from their practical experience and hands-on perspective.

Each could be complementing the other, but their judgments might set them in opposing corners. Companies lose resources when divergent personality styles fail to appreciate each other's value, and stubbornly insisting that one style is superior to the other limits the contributions of the person doing the insisting.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Sentinel Cooperation

Finding Commonality

Protagonists may be tempted to view Sentinels as unimaginative or rigid, but the efficiency and stability they offer are necessary to any organization – when they commit, they get things done. Keeping that in mind when trying to communicate can help. When Protagonists minimize abstract terms, and focus on concrete steps, not only can they cooperate more efficiently with Sentinels, but the approach also helps them tame their more abstract ideas so that they become part of concrete solutions.

For example, Sentinels can feel lost when faced with some vague but impassioned notions, such as the importance of stable work schedules to human dignity. To them, it just sounds like anger untethered from practical results. To help resolve such miscommunication, Protagonists might try the following:

- Present information in practical terms.
    - In relation to the above example: An employee has eight hours between shifts, but it takes one hour for the round-trip commute to work. People need eight hours of sleep, but this employee is only able to get seven, if that. By breaking down this problem in concrete terms, Sentinels and Protagonists can work together to come up with a solution for this employee. Sentinels care about people, too. They just need things to be constructed differently.
- Avoid expressing things in terms of ideal and abstract notions.
- Consider asking Sentinels for direction. Although Protagonists have plenty of organizational skills, details are not always part of their

big-picture approach. Working side-by-side with a Sentinel is likely to put you in touch with those details.

- Set clear, incremental targets when working with Sentinels. They're not slow, but when they commit, they put considerable time and energy into getting things done. They want to know they're using that focus effectively.
- Show appreciation for what they do, rather than pointing out what they could do differently; it can go a long way in improving cooperation.

For Protagonists working with Sentinels, focus is best placed on turning the abstract into the concrete, the broader perspective into the more specific. This doesn't mean Protagonists have to abandon their ideals or points of view; adding a practical dimension will help.

A Single Perspective Isn't Enough

These two personality types can resolve their problems by understanding that both worldviews have something to offer. Practicing patience in the face of pronounced differences is good advice that both can embrace. Both Protagonists and Sentinels should be careful not to judge their coworkers' approaches to their jobs as wrong merely because they're unfamiliar.

Phrases like "That's the way we've always done it" or "That's what you're supposed to do" hold little weight for Protagonists. Lots of things used to be done certain ways before they were improved upon, and Sentinels themselves often embrace past improvements. Taking a step back to reflect on this (patience and thoughtfulness tend to go together) can go a long way toward moving things along.

Protagonists who hope to help Sentinels work more effectively with them might try some of the following strategies:

- Highlight similar goals. They likely exist, even if they are seen from two very distinct perspectives.
- Think in terms of results.

- Include optimism in the mix. Both want things to be better and for all to benefit from their work. That point of common interest may help Sentinels buy into Protagonists' dreams and Protagonists accept Sentinels' hands-on approach.
- To build rapport, talk about rules and established structures with Sentinels.
- Be true to your interest in transformative ideas and methods. However, in consideration of more traditional Sentinel coworkers, take a gentle approach to introducing new ideas.

Protagonists should show Sentinels the value they bring to the table. Fortunately, Protagonists are perhaps the most organized and action-oriented Diplomats, so there is plenty to show. However, both types should be careful to avoid being too dogmatic about their own approaches if they are to make a successful team.

Protagonist–Explorer Cooperation

Balanced Protagonist–Explorer Cooperation

Action-Oriented Partnership

Protagonists and Explorers both enjoy moving forward with tasks and finding better ways of doing things. Finding novel, compelling solutions to practical and concrete problems stimulates Explorers. They can take a tangled mess of a situation and figure out how to make it work, often in unique and exciting ways – so long as they're allowed to do it their way. For Protagonists, work is more broadly about personal vision, development, and well-being: problem-solving on a grand scale. They can flip a fixed idea on its head, creating a whole new perspective.

Despite their different perspectives, both types respect flexibility, and rules and traditions don't bind either type too tightly. Explorers are much more utilitarian compared to Protagonists' idealistic pursuit of values, but they share a common appreciation for innovation and constructive change.

Ideas and Techniques

Partnerships between these two types can offer a lot to the workplace if they can make it work. Protagonists are great at grasping, creating, and transforming ideas, but they're theoretical and thought based, and they often struggle to fit such big ideas into such a small world. Explorers excel at hands-on activity. They relish mastery of people, things, and skills within their physical environment. To see Protagonists' visions realized, call on Explorers. They can do much together if they decide to collaborate on a task or project.

Imagine the mood in an organization has grown glum. Protagonists might use their visionary approach to realize there's no real sense of community. They can sense that communication is poor, and they can detect a lack of connection with their clients and among coworkers. If Protagonists bring this concern and their vision for a cohesive group to Explorers' attention, they might create an email newsletter, a phone chain, a podcast, or a monthly coffee "date" for coworkers to get people together and build a sense of community. They might generate a brand for the organization that says, "Community" and, in doing so, also fashion a morale-raising team of Protagonists and Explorers. These two different pieces of the puzzle have much potential to fit together.

Unbalanced Protagonist–Explorer Cooperation

Heavy and Light Standards

Although established standards don't bind either Explorers or Protagonists as tightly as they might Sentinels, Protagonists do live by a firm code. Their values, usually connected to their thoughtfulness and ethics, are strong forces in their lives. Explorers aren't necessarily amoral, but broad values aren't always as prominent as a desire for results in the way they handle business.

Extraverted Explorers enjoy people and are often friendly, outgoing, and fun, building vast networks of friends and clients – often with little distinction between the two. In business, the goal is to make money, so they may happily use their personal networks to sell themselves or their goods. This mixture would almost certainly offend Protagonists' sense of authenticity, but to Explorers, it's just people helping each other out by making an exchange. To their minds, if everyone involved is happy, who cares?

Deep and Spontaneous

When Protagonists' values are dismissed, if they are insecure, they tend to respond poorly. Differences in opinion may lead to biased, negative outlooks, with Protagonists seeing Explorers as shallow or selfish; conversely, intolerant Explorers may, in turn, regard Protagonists as "uptight dreamers" disconnected from reality. Explorers live in the here and now, but Protagonists freely revel in imagination and thought – it's the classic conflict between immediate results and long-term ideals. The answer to this difference is for each to recognize what the other brings to the table.

Consider this hospital metaphor. Protagonists would be the case managers, equipped to handle the long-term well-being and treatment of patients in a holistic way. Meanwhile, Explorers would be down in the emergency room, doing triage and reattaching limbs – they don't have a month to see how things go. Both have different attitudes about what it means to save a life – *but they're both saving lives*. The two roles require pronounced differences in approach, plans of action, and styles of communication, but both are needed to run a hospital.

The potential problem is obvious. Those doing triage may see themselves as the real heroes, and case managers may believe they make it possible for "real" long-term healing to occur. This less than cooperative regard – maybe even disdain – for the value of the other's style can lead to disharmony and perhaps even harmful competition.

Rebalancing Protagonist–Explorer Cooperation

Keeping It Real

Improving working relationships with Explorers requires Protagonists to make a bit of adjustment to their natural approach to dealing with others. Focusing on how to make an issue actionable is often vital for effective communication with Explorers. Protagonists certainly love new ideas, but they can lose them if they get mired in lofty philosophical theories that are well beyond what's needed to act. Explorers are usually more interested in how an idea can be put into practice.

Protagonists have a lot to learn here. They have a clear idea of what the big picture looks like, but it's helpful to see details and processes in action as well. Protagonists can ask questions and participate with their two hands, experiencing the moment one step at a time. As action-oriented individuals, Protagonists can easily fall into productive harmony with Explorers, once they move past theory and the work commences.

Protagonists can facilitate communication with Explorers if they keep the following in mind:

- Avoid the theoretical. Focus on that which can be manipulated physically. The more kinetic the better.
- Look for the action-oriented common ground. It's there, but sometimes it's hidden under Protagonists' broader idealism. Ask, "What is it we want to *do* together?" Think concrete and measurable.
- Look for what excites the other person and try to join them in that excitement – or at least appreciate that they are excited. Both types are passionate, although for different reasons and in different ways.

Nobody is so complete that they can't benefit from the gifts diverse types bring to the workplace. In many ways, Explorers are vastly different from Protagonists, and therein lies their value to each other.

The Power of a Notion

Protagonists tend to extend their values and ideals into their work life as much as they can, knowing that what drives them will improve communication and motivation. Explorers looking to cooperate more

closely with Protagonist coworkers can start by asking about their values and connecting those values to real examples.

Protagonists also tend to think big, looking at the broad picture rather than the specifics or details. A little enthusiasm for an idea with potential goes a long way. When Explorers can help them turn it into something real, they can be a powerful team.

Protagonists who hope to help Explorers work more effectively with them might try some of the following strategies:

- Be assertive (not aggressive) in advocating for the things that are important to you. Just because Explorers are less interested in values and abstract ideas doesn't mean you have to surrender that part of yourself to work with them. However, do so in a diplomatic fashion that sets boundaries while avoiding rigidity or hostility.
- Show interest in Explorers' projects. Let them know that, even though you both may have obvious differences in your approaches, you respect them for what they do best.
- As with all Observant types, focus on outcomes. Find common interests there. Shared goals can bind workers to each other and build cohesiveness.

These two action-oriented types can be a dynamic force in the workplace if they decide to shed concerns about differences and embrace them instead. Explorers can help Protagonists not wander too far into conceptual weeds, and Protagonists can provide solid ground for Explorers, who often end up on unsteady, shifting sands if left to their own devices.

Conclusion

Is it a job or is it a mission? Protagonists are likely to say "both." Protagonists don't accept work as a mere job – yet they are not likely to exalt themselves above their fellow employees who simply want to make a buck. For them, their work life is a hybrid of a calling and a need for survival like everyone else. When they balance the two, their enthusiasm and dedication give them an edge. Their charisma, persuasiveness,

and other leadership abilities allow them to impact their workplaces in impressive ways, and others tend to value their contributions.

Obviously, there is no perfect Protagonist specimen. Despite a common core of traits, each Protagonist adapts and translates their shared traits into their own unique expression. And there is no perfect job for any type, nor one that is totally unsuitable. However, some positions may be more aligned Protagonists' traits and some less aligned. Hopefully, this guide can help any who read it find the path that suits them most, according to their own mission, goals, and values. For Protagonists, that path is filled with meaning and humanity.

Final Words

Going Forth to Do What's Right

Driven and idealistic, Protagonists want to lead lives of meaning and purpose – lives that leave the world a better place. This mission means a great deal to them, and as they pursue it, they may see anything short of complete success as a frustrating failure.

But most of life is lived somewhere between success and failure. Protagonists may find the greatest satisfaction and progress in their academic and professional endeavors when they focus less on whether they've made as much progress as they already "should" have and more on continuing to strive in the right direction.

As they go after their goals, everyone encounters setbacks – even the most dedicated of Protagonists. But over time, people with this personality type often find that taking small, positive steps can lead to great results. These pages have outlined many positive steps that Protagonists can take – ways that they can enhance their learning experiences, align their careers with their sense of purpose, and cultivate healthy, collaborative relationships with their colleagues. Our hope is that these insights offer you the clarity and the motivation to pursue a lifelong path of learning and a professional life that leave you feeling inspired and fulfilled.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you on your professional development journey? Explore our Career Tools and Assessments.
- Looking to enhance your friendships, romantic relationships, or family relationships? Check out the *Protagonist Guide to Relationships*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Protagonist Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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